
NOBODY
LEFT
TOTAL CASH

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NOBODY LEFT

Some stories get recorded. Some are safer if they never leave the room.

Reese Calloway left Millbrook Falls at eighteen and built a career asking other people the hard questions. Now she is back — a true-crime podcaster with a recorder, a thin case file, and a disappearance the whole town still treats as folklore. Lauren Foss vanished in 2004. Her parents never stopped waiting. Reese thinks she is here to make an episode.

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A Note from the Author / Publisher

We have spent years listening to stories about missing people as if the microphone were a kind of justice — as if asking the next question were the same as being careful. This book started from a quieter unease: what happens when the person doing the asking is from the town, and the town already has a way of keeping someone safe that never made it into a file.

Nobody Left is not a lecture about true crime. It is a novel about homecoming, about a recorder that can be left in a bag, and about the difference between finding something and being entitled to it. We wanted the discomfort to sit. We wanted the sheriff to be complicated. We wanted the work of journalism to look like work — motel desks, thin folders, calls from a producer who needs pages by Friday.

If you have ever wondered who owns a story, this is the book we made for that wondering.

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A note on process: this book was produced with the assistance of AI language models — in the same way an author might use a ghostwriter or editor. The ideas, concept, characters, argument, and creative direction are entirely the author's own. AI was used as a writing tool — the thinking behind every page is human.

Acknowledgements

Thank you to the early readers whose feedback helped shape this book.

This book is published through GetFreeEbooks, a platform built on a simple idea: that good books should be easy to find, and free to read. Thank you to that community of readers and writers for giving books like this one a place to land.

Chapter 1: Homecoming

The bridge announced itself the way it always had—metal grating under the tires, a rhythmic thrum that said you were almost there. Reese gripped the wheel of the rental car and watched the river below, low and sluggish in the late summer heat. The water looked smaller than she remembered, the way everything in Millbrook Falls probably would.

Three years since her last visit. Longer, really, if she counted visits that mattered.

The town came into view on the other side of the bridge: one main street, a church steeple, the water tower with its faded paint. She could see the feed store, the post office, the diner with its flickering neon sign. Nothing had changed. That was somehow worse than if it had burned down and been rebuilt as condos.

Reese eased off the gas and rolled through the stop sign at the end of the bridge. No one was coming. No one was ever coming.

She'd told herself this trip was professional—just another case, just another episode. She'd told Marisol the same thing when she pitched it. "Lauren Foss. Disappeared 2004. Small-town mystery, never solved. I can get access because I'm from there." Marisol had approved the budget without even asking why Reese hadn't covered it sooner. Maybe she knew better than to ask.

The motel was two blocks past the hardware store, next to the gas station that used to be a Dairy Queen. Reese pulled into the lot and cut the engine. The silence felt heavier here. No city hum, no traffic, just the faint buzz of cicadas and the distant rumble of a truck on the county road.

The front desk was unmanned. Reese rang the bell and waited, her duffel bag slung over one shoulder, her equipment case in the other hand. After a minute, a woman in her fifties emerged from the back room, wiping her hands on a dishtowel.

"Help you?"

"I have a reservation. Calloway."

The woman's face shifted—not quite recognition, but something close. "You're Bill Hendrick's niece, aren't you? The one who went to the Cities."

"That's me." Reese tried to smile. She wasn't Bill Hendrick's niece. Her uncle had moved to Arizona fifteen years ago. But correcting people in Millbrook Falls was like trying to edit a story that had already been printed.

"Room six. Quiet this time of year." The woman handed over a key—an actual key, not a card—and gestured toward the row of identical doors. "You here for long?"

"A few days. Maybe a week."

“Well. Welcome back.”

Reese nodded and walked to the room. The key stuck in the lock, then gave with a reluctant click.

* * *

The room smelled like bleach and old carpet. Reese set the equipment case on the desk—laminate, chipped at the corners—and unzipped it carefully. Recorder, microphone, windscreen, cables. She’d packed it the same way for five years, muscle memory by now. The recorder powered on with a soft beep. She clipped the mic to the stand, adjusted the levels, and spoke into it.

“Testing. One, two. Reese Calloway, Millbrook Falls, day one.”

Her voice came back through the headphones, clear and flat. She made a note in her phone: *check ambient noise at Foss house, bring windscreen.*

The mini-fridge hummed in the corner. Reese sat on the edge of the bed and stared at the blank wall. She could do this. She’d done harder interviews. She’d sat across from a man who’d been acquitted of killing his wife and asked him how he slept at night. She’d doorstepped a grieving mother who didn’t want to talk and convinced her it mattered. This was just another case.

Except it wasn’t.

She pulled out her notebook and flipped to the page where she’d sketched the episode outline. *Lauren Foss, 19, disappeared March 14, 2004. Engaged to be married. No body, no leads, no resolution.* Beneath that, she’d written: *Why does this story still matter?* She’d underlined it twice, but she still didn’t have an answer.

The truth was, she didn’t know if it did. Most cold cases didn’t. They mattered to the families, sure, but to listeners? Half her audience just wanted something to play while they did the dishes. She was good at pretending that didn’t bother her.

Reese stood and grabbed her keys. The interview with Karen and Bill Foss was in an hour. She should eat something first, but the thought of food made her stomach tighten. Instead, she checked the mic levels one more time, slipped the recorder into her bag, and left the room.

* * *

The Foss house was on Maple Street, a narrow two-story with white siding and a sagging front porch. Reese had looked it up on the satellite view before she left Minneapolis, but seeing it in person was different. The lawn was mowed but not cared for. The paint was clean but faded. It looked like a house where time had stopped and no one had noticed.

Reese parked on the street and sat for a moment, rehearsing her opening. *Thank you for*

agreeing to talk with me. I know this is difficult. I want to honor Lauren's story. It sounded hollow even in her head.

She grabbed her bag and walked up the cracked driveway. The doorbell didn't work—she could hear it trying and failing inside—so she knocked instead.

Karen Foss opened the door almost immediately, as if she'd been waiting just inside. She was in her seventies, white-haired, wearing a cardigan even in the heat. Her smile was polite and fragile.

"You must be Reese. Come in, come in."

The house smelled like coffee and something older, something Reese couldn't name. Carpet that had been vacuumed too many times. Air that didn't move. Karen led her into the living room, where Bill was already sitting in a recliner by the window. He was older than Karen, thinner, his hands folded in his lap. He nodded at Reese but didn't stand.

"Bill doesn't hear so well anymore," Karen said, settling onto the couch. "But he wanted to be here."

"I appreciate that." Reese set her bag on the floor and pulled out the recorder. "Do you mind if I record this? It helps me remember details. I won't use anything you're not comfortable with."

"That's fine." Karen's hands were already gripping a framed photo from the side table—Lauren at what looked like high school graduation, cap and gown, smiling. "You grew up here, didn't you? I remember your mother. She worked at the library."

"She did." Reese hit record and set the mic on the coffee table between them. "Thank you again for talking with me. I know the case has been covered before, but I wanted to come back to it. See if there's something people missed."

Karen nodded, still holding the photo. "Everyone always says that. But no one ever finds anything."

Bill shifted in his chair. "You got questions or not?"

Reese took out her notebook. "I do. I've read the police reports, the news coverage, but I wanted to hear it from you. What happened the day Lauren disappeared?"

Karen exhaled slowly, like she'd told this story a hundred times and it never got easier. "It was a Sunday. She was supposed to come for dinner after church. She didn't go to church with us anymore—she and her fiancé went to the evening service sometimes—but she always came for Sunday dinner. Always."

"And she didn't show up."

"No. We waited. I called her apartment. No answer. I called his family's house—her fiancé's. They said they hadn't seen her either." Karen set the photo down and picked up another one, this time from the mantel: Lauren at a picnic, laughing, holding a paper plate. "We thought

maybe they'd gone somewhere. Taken a drive. But by Monday morning, when she didn't show up for work, we knew something was wrong."

"Who reported her missing?"

"I did," Karen said. "I went to the sheriff's office first thing Monday. They said to wait twenty-four hours, but I told them she wouldn't just leave. Not like that. Not without telling us."

Bill leaned forward slightly. "They didn't listen. Took them three days to even start looking."

Reese wrote that down. "And the investigation—what did they find?"

"Nothing." Karen's voice cracked. She cleared her throat and tried again. "Her car was in the driveway at her apartment. Her purse was inside. No signs of a struggle. The sheriff at the time—Roy Macklin, he's passed now—said maybe she just needed space. Maybe she called off the wedding and left."

"But you didn't believe that."

"She wouldn't do that." Karen's hands tightened on the photo frame. "Not to us. She was a good girl. She would've told us if something was wrong."

The room settled into a heavy quiet. Reese let it sit, her pen still on the page. Bill was staring out the window, his jaw working. Karen was looking at the photos—there were dozens of them, Reese realized. On the walls, on the mantel, on every flat surface. Lauren at five, at ten, at sixteen. Lauren in a prom dress. Lauren holding a diploma. All of them frozen, all of them watching.

"Her room is still the same," Karen said quietly. "Upstairs. I haven't changed anything. In case she comes back."

Reese didn't write that down. She'd heard it before, from other families. The room left untouched, the clothes still in the closet, the bed still made. It was a kind of waiting that didn't have an end.

"What do you want people to know about Lauren?" Reese asked. "If they listen to this episode, what should they understand?"

Karen looked up, her eyes wet. "I just want to know she didn't suffer. That's all. I don't care if we ever know what happened, really. I just want to know she's not—" She stopped, pressed her hand to her mouth.

Bill spoke without turning from the window. "She wants to know if our daughter's dead. That's what she's saying."

"Bill—"

"It's been twenty-two years, Karen. She's not coming home."

The silence that followed felt like a fissure opening in the middle of the room. Reese kept her face

neutral, her pen still, and waited. She'd learned a long time ago that the best interviews happened in the spaces between questions.

Karen set the photo down carefully and folded her hands in her lap. "You'll do your best, won't you? To find out what happened?"

Reese nodded. "I will."

It wasn't a promise. It was close enough.

* * *

The sheriff's office was on the ground floor of the county building, a blocky structure that looked like it had been built in the seventies and forgotten. Reese pushed through the glass door and approached the front desk, where a young deputy was typing on a computer that belonged in a museum.

"Help you?"

"I'm here to see Sheriff Tozer. I called ahead—Reese Calloway."

The deputy nodded and picked up the phone. A minute later, a man in his sixties emerged from a back hallway, wearing the kind of uniform that was pressed but not new. He was tall, weathered, with a face that gave nothing away.

"Ms. Calloway. Earl Tozer." He extended a hand, and Reese shook it. His grip was firm but not aggressive. "You wanted to talk about the Foss case."

"If you have time."

"I've got a few minutes. Come on back."

Reese followed him down the hall to a small office with a metal desk, a filing cabinet, and a bulletin board covered in flyers. She caught sight of one: *Lauren Foss. Missing since March 14, 2004.* The photo was the same one from the living room—Lauren at graduation, smiling.

Tozer gestured to a chair and sat behind the desk. "You're doing a podcast, that right?"

"That's right. I focus on cold cases. Unsolved disappearances."

"Uh-huh." He leaned back in his chair, fingers steepled. "And you think you'll find something we missed?"

"I think there's always value in taking another look. Especially after this much time." Reese kept her tone even. She'd learned not to sound accusatory. Sheriffs didn't respond well to that. "I was hoping to review the original case file. I know there were some reports filed in 2004, interviews conducted. I'd like to see what's on record."

Tozer studied her for a long moment, then stood and went to the filing cabinet. He pulled a folder

from the bottom drawer and set it on the desk in front of her.

It was thin. Too thin.

Reese opened it carefully. There was an initial missing person report, filed by Karen Foss. A few interview notes—neighbors, coworkers, the fiancé. A summary from the lead investigator at the time. And that was it. No follow-up reports. No search logs. No updates after the first month.

“This is everything?” Reese asked.

“That’s what we’ve got.”

“No search records? No evidence logs?”

“There wasn’t much to search. Like I said, the original investigator did what he could. Sometimes people just leave.”

Reese looked up at him. “Do you believe that? That she just left?”

Tozer’s face didn’t change. “I believe we did everything we could with what we had. If you find something new, I’ll be the first to reopen it. But after twenty-two years?” He shook his head. “I wouldn’t get the family’s hopes up.”

“Can I make copies of this?”

“Sure. Deputy out front can help you.” He stood, signaling the conversation was over. “Anything else you need, you let me know.”

Reese gathered the thin file and followed him back to the lobby. The fluorescent lights buzzed overhead. The faded missing person flyer on the bulletin board watched her as she left.

* * *

By the time Reese made it to the diner, the sun was low and the heat had softened into something bearable. The place was called Rosie’s, though Reese didn’t remember anyone named Rosie ever working there. It was the kind of diner that smelled like fryer grease and served breakfast all day, the kind of place that was the only option after seven.

She slid into a booth by the window and ordered a burger and coffee from a waitress who didn’t recognize her. Across the room, two men in their fifties sat at the counter, talking in low voices. Reese pulled out her notebook and flipped through her notes from the day, but she wasn’t really reading them. She was listening.

“—still can’t believe they’re tearing down the old Macklin place,” one of the men was saying.

“About time. Thing’s been empty for years.”

“You remember when Roy Macklin was sheriff? That was back when this town still had some sense.”

“Roy was all right. Didn’t do much about that Foss girl, though.”

Reese’s pen stopped.

“What was he supposed to do? She ran off. Probably didn’t want to marry that Holcomb boy.”

“Maybe. My wife swears she saw someone who looked just like her at the hardware store last year. Said it gave her the chills.”

The other man laughed. “Come on. Everyone looks like someone you used to know when you get to our age.”

“I’m just saying what she said.”

The conversation shifted to property taxes. Reese wrote in her notebook: *Hardware store. Someone who looked like Lauren?* She circled it twice, then underlined it.

Probably nothing. Small towns were full of ghost stories, people who swore they’d seen someone who’d been gone for years. But Reese had learned to write everything down. Most of it was noise. Occasionally, it wasn’t.

She finished her burger, left cash on the table, and walked back to the motel as the streetlights flickered on.

* * *

The motel room was exactly as she’d left it: depressing and anonymous. Reese locked the door, kicked off her shoes, and sat at the desk with her headphones on. She pulled up the recording from the Foss interview and hit play.

Karen’s voice filled her ears, tinny and close. *I just want to know she didn’t suffer.*

Reese listened to the whole thing, making notes in the margins of her notebook. Time stamps for the parts she might use. Moments where Karen’s voice broke. The long silence after Bill said, *She’s not coming home.*

When it was over, Reese sat in the quiet and stared at the notebook. The comment about the hardware store was still circled twice, sitting at the bottom of the page like a question she didn’t know how to ask yet.

She opened her laptop and searched for recent photos of Millbrook Falls. The hardware store came up in a few images—Main Street, late afternoon, a woman standing behind the counter. The photo was too grainy to see her face clearly, but Reese stared at it anyway.

Probably nothing.

She closed the laptop and looked at the case file she’d copied at the sheriff’s office. The folder sat on the desk, thin and incomplete. Something about it nagged at her—not what was in it, but what wasn’t.

Reese opened her notebook again and wrote: *Why so little follow-up? Why did the investigation stop after a month?*

No answers. Just more questions.

She leaned back in the chair and rubbed her eyes. Tomorrow she'd start interviewing people who'd known Lauren. Teachers, friends, coworkers. The usual steps. Maybe someone would remember something new. Maybe not. Either way, she'd have tape, and tape was what mattered.

That was what she told herself, anyway.

Outside, the cicadas hummed. The neon sign from the gas station next door cast a faint red glow through the curtains. Reese sat in the half-light and thought about Karen's hands gripping that photo, about the room upstairs that hadn't changed in twenty-two years, about the way Bill had said *She's not coming home* like he was letting go of something he'd been holding too long.

She didn't know yet if this story mattered.

But she was here. And for now, that would have to be enough.

Chapter 2: The Woman at the Counter

The hardware store was on Main Street, sandwiched between the post office and a barber shop that looked like it hadn't updated its prices since 1987. Reese pushed through the front door mid-morning, and the bell overhead announced her arrival with a cheerful jangle that felt out of place.

The smell hit her first: sawdust and motor oil, paint thinner and something vaguely metallic. The aisles were narrow, stocked floor to ceiling with tools and supplies she couldn't name. A few other customers moved through the space—an older man comparing drill bits, a woman in overalls reading the back of a paint can.

Reese headed for the counter at the back. She needed batteries for the recorder. The ones she'd brought were fine, but it gave her a reason to be here, and she'd learned a long time ago that hardware stores were good places to listen. People talked while they shopped. Small-town hardware stores, especially.

The woman behind the register was in her early forties, dark hair pulled back in a low ponytail. She was efficient, polite, handing change to a customer and bagging a set of hinges without looking up. When the customer left, she glanced at Reese.

"Help you find something?"

Reese's breath caught. Just for a second.

It was nothing concrete—just the tilt of the woman's head, the shape of her face, something about the way she stood. Reese had spent yesterday afternoon staring at photos of Lauren Foss. The mind played tricks when you spent too long looking at old images.

"Batteries," Reese said. "Double-A."

"Aisle three, about halfway back."

"Thanks."

Reese walked down the aisle, grabbed a pack of batteries she didn't need, and came back to the counter. The nameplate next to the register said *Dana Whitfield*.

Dana rang up the purchase without comment. Her hands moved quickly, practiced. Reese watched her face, trying not to stare, trying to look like a customer who just wanted batteries and nothing more.

Their eyes met for a second. Dana went very still.

Then she blinked, and the moment passed. She finished ringing up the sale, handed Reese the receipt, and smiled. Polite. Professional. Nothing more.

"Have a good day."

“You too.”

Reese left the store and walked back to her car, the batteries in her bag and her pulse louder than it should have been. She sat behind the wheel for a minute, trying to talk herself down.

It was nothing. Small towns were full of people who looked vaguely like other people. The mind filled in gaps. She’d been looking at Lauren’s photos all day yesterday; of course she’d see resemblances where there weren’t any.

Except Dana had gone still. Just for a second, but Reese had seen it.

Probably nothing.

She started the car and drove back to the motel.

* * *

Over the next two days, Reese worked through her list of interviews. She started with Mrs. Hendricks, Lauren’s high school English teacher, who met her at a coffee shop just outside town. Mrs. Hendricks was in her seventies now, retired, sharp-eyed behind wire-rimmed glasses.

“Lauren was bright,” she said, stirring sugar into her tea. “Quiet, but not shy. She wrote beautifully. I remember thinking she’d go into journalism, maybe. She had a way with words.”

“Did she seem troubled? In the months before she disappeared?”

Mrs. Hendricks paused, the spoon hovering over her cup. “No. But then, the quiet ones are good at hiding trouble, aren’t they?”

Reese recorded the whole conversation, asked follow-up questions, and left with nothing new.

The next interview was with Janet Kowalski, the family friend who’d reported Lauren missing after she didn’t show up for Sunday dinner. Janet lived in a tidy ranch house on the edge of town, and she answered the door holding a dish towel and a cautious smile.

“I told the police everything I knew back then,” she said, leading Reese into the living room. “I don’t know what else I can add.”

“Sometimes people remember details later,” Reese said. “Things that didn’t seem important at the time.”

Janet sat on the edge of the couch, hands folded in her lap. “Lauren was a sweet girl. Kind. She helped out at church—taught Sunday school for the younger kids. She and that boy she was engaged to, they seemed happy. I thought they’d get married, have kids, the whole thing.”

“What was he like? The fiancé?”

“Nice enough. Polite. His family had money—the Holcombs, you know. Big name around here. I

think Karen and Bill were nervous about it, to be honest. Worried Lauren was marrying up and might not fit in."

"Did Lauren seem nervous?"

"Not that I saw. But like I said, she was sweet. She wouldn't have complained even if she was."

Reese took notes, asked about the day Lauren disappeared, and got the same story she'd heard from Karen and Bill. No new details. No inconsistencies. Just the same fifteen-minute window where Lauren was supposed to show up and didn't.

The last interview was with Ethan Pruitt, a guy who'd gone to high school with Lauren. Reese tracked him down at the garage where he worked, and he agreed to talk during his lunch break. They sat on a bench outside, the smell of oil and exhaust thick in the air.

"I didn't know her that well," Ethan said, unwrapping a sandwich. "We had a few classes together, but she ran with a different crowd. The good kids, you know? I was more of a burnout."

"Did you ever talk to her?"

"A few times. She was nice. Didn't treat me like I was invisible, which was more than some people did." He took a bite, chewed thoughtfully. "I remember hearing she disappeared. Everyone was talking about it. Some people thought she ran off, some thought something bad happened. I don't know. I hope she's okay, wherever she is."

That was it. Reese thanked him, packed up her recorder, and drove back to the motel with a bag full of tape that said nothing new.

That night, she sat at the desk with her headphones on and listened to all three interviews back to back. Mrs. Hendricks' careful pauses. Janet's nervous hands. Ethan's casual shrug. The voices blurred together after a while, all of them saying the same thing in different words: *Lauren was nice. Lauren was quiet. Lauren disappeared. We don't know why.*

Reese pulled the headphones off and rubbed her eyes. The story was stale. She'd known it might be—twenty-two years was a long time—but she'd hoped for something. A detail that didn't make it into the original reports. A contradiction. Anything.

Instead, she had a thin case file, three interviews that added nothing, and a comment overheard at the diner about someone at the hardware store.

Reese looked at her notebook. The hardware store comment was still circled twice.

She thought about Dana Whitfield. The way she'd gone still when their eyes met. The tilt of her head.

Probably nothing.

But Reese couldn't stop thinking about it.

* * *

The next morning, she went back to the hardware store.

This time, she had a plan. She walked in, batteries in hand, and approached the counter.

Dana looked up. Her expression didn't change, but Reese saw the flicker of recognition. Just a fraction of a second.

"Hi," Reese said. "I bought these yesterday, but I grabbed the wrong size. Can I exchange them?"

Dana glanced at the unopened package. "Sure. What size do you need?"

"Triple-A."

"Aisle three."

Reese walked to the aisle, grabbed a different pack, and came back. This time, she watched Dana more carefully. The way she moved—deliberate, economical, like someone who'd worked retail long enough to make every gesture efficient. The way she tilted her head slightly when she listened, as if she was deciding whether the question deserved an answer before she gave one.

Reese had seen that head tilt in a photo. Lauren at a picnic, laughing, holding a paper plate.

Dana reached for the register, and her sleeve pulled back slightly. Just for a second, Reese saw it: a small birthmark on her left wrist. Dark, oval-shaped. Unmistakable.

Reese's heart pounded so loud she was sure Dana could hear it. She kept her face neutral, her voice casual.

"Thanks."

"No problem." Dana handed her the receipt and the new batteries. Her expression hadn't changed. Polite. Professional. Giving nothing away.

Reese left the store, walked to her car, and sat behind the wheel with her hands shaking.

A birthmark. On the left wrist.

It could be a coincidence. People had birthmarks. But Reese had seen dozens of photos of Lauren Foss over the past three days, and she remembered one specifically: Lauren at a family picnic, 2003. Her left wrist had been visible in the photo, resting on the edge of a folding table. Same birthmark. Same placement.

Reese pulled out her phone and opened the photo she'd saved from the case file. She zoomed in. The resolution was grainy, but it was there. Left wrist. Oval-shaped. Dark.

She sat in the car for ten minutes, staring at the photo, trying to talk herself out of what she was thinking.

It wasn't possible. People didn't just disappear for twenty-two years and come back to live three streets from their parents under a different name. That didn't happen.

Except maybe it did.

Reese started the car and drove back to the motel, her hands still shaking.

* * *

She didn't sleep that night.

Instead, she spread the case file across the motel desk and went through it page by page. The missing person report. The interview notes. The summary from the original investigator. And the photos—three of them, all printed on cheap copy paper, all dated 2003 or early 2004.

One was the graduation photo Karen had shown her. One was a family snapshot at Christmas. And the third was the picnic photo: Lauren laughing, holding a paper plate, her left wrist resting on the table. The birthmark was visible, just barely, at the edge of the frame.

Reese opened her laptop and searched for more photos. She found a few in old news articles from 2004, scanned and archived by the local paper. Lauren at a church event. Lauren at a high school basketball game. Most of them were too low-resolution to see details, but one—a candid shot from someone's graduation party—showed Lauren mid-laugh, her head tilted to the side. Same angle. Same tilt.

Reese pulled up the image she'd taken on her phone earlier that day: Dana behind the counter, mid-transaction, her head angled slightly as she looked at the register. She put the two photos side by side on her laptop screen.

The tilt was the same.

Reese leaned back in the chair and stared at the screen. Her chest felt tight, her thoughts moving too fast to pin down.

This was impossible. This didn't happen. People didn't vanish for twenty-two years and come back as someone else. Lauren Foss was dead, or she'd started a new life somewhere far away, or she'd had an accident and her body was somewhere the search teams never found. She wasn't working at a hardware store in Millbrook Falls under the name Dana Whitfield.

Except she was.

Reese was certain. Not "probably," not "maybe." Certain.

Dana Whitfield was Lauren Foss.

She sat in the quiet of the motel room, listening to her own breathing, and tried to figure out what the hell she was supposed to do with that information.

Her phone buzzed. A text from Marisol.

How's it going? Any good tape yet?

Reese stared at the message. She could call Marisol right now. Tell her what she'd found. Marisol would know exactly what to do—she always did. She'd tell Reese to confirm it, get Dana on tape, break the story wide open. *Lauren Foss alive after 22 years. Exclusive interview. Major networks will pick it up.*

Reese typed a reply: *Still gathering. Will update soon.*

She hit send and put the phone down.

She could call Tozer. Tell him she'd found Lauren. But Tozer had given her a file that was too thin, and something about the way he'd looked at her when he said *sometimes people just leave* made her think he already knew more than he was saying.

She could call Karen and Bill. Walk up to their door and say, *Your daughter is alive. She's been here the whole time. She works at the hardware store.* She imagined Karen's face. The way the news would break her open, or piece her back together, or both at once.

Reese pulled her hands through her hair and pressed the heels of her palms against her eyes.

She had the answer. She'd come to Millbrook Falls to find out what happened to Lauren Foss, and now she knew. Lauren hadn't been killed. She hadn't been abducted. She'd left. And for reasons Reese didn't understand yet, she'd come back and stayed, hiding in plain sight, three streets from the people who thought she was dead.

The question wasn't *what happened to Lauren Foss* anymore.

The question was *what the hell was Reese supposed to do about it?*

* * *

She didn't call anyone.

Instead, the next evening, she drove to the hardware store at closing time and parked across the street. She turned off the engine and waited.

At six o'clock, the lights inside dimmed. A few minutes later, Dana emerged, locking the door behind her. She walked across the small parking lot to a sensible sedan—nothing flashy, nothing that drew attention—and got in.

Reese watched her drive away.

Her phone was in her hand. Marisol's name was at the top of her recent calls. She could tap it right now. Two rings, maybe three, and Marisol would answer. *You're not going to believe this*, Reese would say, and Marisol would listen, and then she'd tell Reese exactly what to do next. Step by step. The way they always did.

But Reese didn't call.

She couldn't explain why. She just knew that the moment she made that call, something would shift. The story would stop being hers. It would become content, angles, interview logistics, release schedules. It would become the thing she was good at—taking someone's pain and turning it into episodes that people listened to while they folded laundry.

And this felt different.

She thought about Dana's face when their eyes had met in the store. The way she'd gone still, just for a second. The polite smile that came after, the practiced efficiency of someone who'd learned how to be invisible.

Lauren Foss had disappeared twenty-two years ago. Dana Whitfield had been living here for eight.

That meant Lauren had chosen to come back. Chosen to stay. Chosen this life, this name, this quiet anonymity three streets from the people who still mourned her.

Reese didn't know why. But she knew it mattered.

She put the phone down, started the engine, and drove back to the motel.

Tomorrow, she'd figure out what to do. Tonight, she just needed to sit with what she knew and try to understand what it meant.

The answer to the mystery was sitting behind a hardware store counter, ringing up paint and hinges and batteries for people who didn't know who she used to be.

And Reese had no idea what came next.

Chapter 3: Off the Record

Reese waited until mid-afternoon, when the lunch rush had cleared and the store would be quietest. She'd driven past twice that morning, watching the parking lot, counting customers. By two o'clock, the hardware store looked empty except for Dana behind the counter.

Reese parked on the street and sat for a minute, trying to rehearse what she'd say. Nothing sounded right. *I know who you are* was too aggressive. *Can we talk about 2004* was too vague. In the end, she just grabbed her bag—no recorder, she'd left it in the motel room deliberately—and walked to the door.

The bell jangled overhead. Dana looked up from the register, and Reese saw the recognition settle into her face. Not surprise. Just a kind of quiet resignation, like she'd been waiting for this.

The store was empty. Fluorescent lights hummed overhead. The smell of sawdust and motor oil hung in the air, thick and familiar.

Reese walked to the counter. Her heart was pounding, but she kept her voice steady.

"Can we talk? Off the record."

Dana's face didn't change for a long moment. Then something shifted—color draining, her jaw tightening slightly. She didn't say *about what* or *I don't know what you mean*. She just looked at Reese, and Reese looked back, and the silence stretched between them like a held breath.

Finally, Dana said, "After work. Not here."

"Where?"

"There's a picnic area by the river. About two miles south on County Road 14. You'll see the sign." Dana's voice was quiet, measured. "I close at six."

"I'll be there."

Dana nodded once and turned back to the register, her hands moving to straighten a stack of receipts that didn't need straightening. Reese left without saying anything else.

Outside, the sun was bright and merciless. Reese walked to her car, got in, and sat there for a minute, shaking.

She'd just asked the question she couldn't un-ask.

* * *

The picnic area was small and unremarkable: two weathered tables under a shelter, a trash can, a sign that said *NO OVERNIGHT CAMPING*. The river ran low and sluggish beyond a thin line of trees, the water brown and uninviting. Reese parked in the gravel lot and waited.

At six fifteen, a sedan pulled in—the same one she'd seen Dana drive away in the other night. Dana got out, glanced at Reese's car, and walked toward the shelter without hesitation. She was still in her work clothes: jeans, a plain shirt, sensible shoes. Her hair was still pulled back. She looked tired.

Reese got out and met her at the picnic table.

Dana didn't sit. She stood with her arms crossed, not defensive exactly, just contained. Waiting.

"You didn't bring your recorder," Dana said.

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because this isn't an interview." Reese paused. "Unless you want it to be."

"I don't."

They stood there for a moment, the river murmuring in the background. A crow called from somewhere in the trees. The light was starting to fade, the sun low and golden through the branches.

Dana finally sat on the bench, her hands folded on the table in front of her. Reese sat across from her, careful to leave space between them.

"How long have you known?" Dana asked.

"A few days. Since I saw the birthmark."

Dana looked down at her left wrist, the small dark oval just visible below her sleeve. "I thought about getting it removed. Years ago. But it seemed like—I don't know. Erasing something that didn't need to be erased."

Reese didn't say anything. She'd learned a long time ago that silence was better than rushing to fill space.

Dana looked up. Her eyes were sharp, watchful. "What do you actually want from me?"

It was a fair question. Reese didn't have a good answer.

"I want to understand," she said finally. "I came here to find out what happened to Lauren Foss. And now I have, but I don't—I don't understand why. Why you came back. Why you've been here for eight years and no one's said anything."

"What makes you think no one's said anything?"

Reese blinked. "Have they?"

Dana's mouth twitched, not quite a smile. "Some people see what they want to see. Some people see more than that and choose not to say anything. And some people just don't look closely

enough.” She paused. “Which one are you?”

“I don’t know yet.”

That was honest, at least.

Dana exhaled slowly and looked out toward the river. The light caught the side of her face, and for a moment Reese could see the shape of the girl in the photos—Lauren at graduation, Lauren at the picnic, Lauren smiling in a dozen different frames on the Fosses’ walls. But there was something else too, something harder and more deliberate. This woman had built herself carefully.

“I had a reason for leaving,” Dana said quietly.

“I know.”

“Do you?”

Reese hesitated. “Janet Kowalski mentioned your fiancé. The Holcombs.”

Dana’s jaw tightened. “Then you know more than most people did back then.”

“Not enough.”

“No,” Dana agreed. “You don’t.”

The river filled the silence again. Reese waited.

Dana spoke without looking at her. “I was nineteen. I thought I was in love. He was twenty-three, good-looking, polite. His family had money—a lot of it. Everyone in town thought it was a good match. My parents were thrilled.”

“But it wasn’t a good match.”

“No.” Dana’s voice was flat. “It started small. He’d tell me what to wear, who I could see, where I could go. I thought it was just—I thought he cared. That’s what I told myself. Then it got worse. He’d get angry if I talked to other people. If I didn’t answer his calls fast enough. If I smiled at someone he didn’t like.”

Reese felt her chest tighten. She’d heard versions of this story before, in other interviews, other cases. It never got easier to hear.

“And then?” she asked gently.

“And then he hit me.” Dana said it simply, without inflection. “Once. Then twice. Then I lost count. He’d apologize after. Say he didn’t mean it. Say I’d made him do it.” She looked down at her hands. “I believed him. For a while, I believed him.”

Reese didn’t move. Didn’t interrupt.

“I tried to call off the wedding,” Dana continued. “Three weeks before it was supposed to

happen. He said no. I said I didn't want to marry him. He said I didn't get to decide that. And I realized—" She stopped, swallowed. "I realized if I stayed, I was going to end up dead. Not right away. But eventually."

The words hung in the air, quiet and final.

"So you left," Reese said.

"So I left." Dana's voice was steadier now, like she'd told this story to herself so many times it had worn smooth. "March fourteenth, 2004. I waited until he was out of town. Packed a bag. Took a bus to Chicago, then another one to St. Louis. Changed my name. Got a job. Built a life that was mine."

"And you never told your parents."

Dana's face didn't change, but Reese saw something flicker in her eyes. Pain, maybe. Or guilt. "I couldn't. If I told them, they'd try to bring me back. Or they'd tell someone, and word would get around, and he'd find me. His family had money. Connections. I couldn't risk it."

"So you let them think you were dead."

"I let them grieve someone who was gone." Dana's voice was quiet, but there was an edge to it. "That's not the same thing."

Reese wanted to argue. She wanted to say that Karen Foss had kept Lauren's room untouched for twenty-two years, that Bill Foss had stopped believing his daughter was coming home, that they'd been living in a kind of frozen hell because they didn't know. But she didn't. Because Dana was right. Lauren *was* gone. The girl who'd been engaged to a Holcomb, who'd taught Sunday school, who'd planned to get married in a church full of people who knew her name—that girl didn't exist anymore.

"Why did you come back?" Reese asked instead.

Dana was quiet for a long time. The river murmured. The light faded another degree.

"Because it was the last place anyone would look for me," she said finally. "I'd been gone eighteen years. He'd moved on—married someone else, had kids. His family still had money, but they weren't looking for me anymore. I thought—" She paused. "I thought I could come home without being Lauren. I could just be Dana. Live quietly. Work at the hardware store. Stay out of the way."

"And it worked."

"For eight years, it worked." Dana looked at Reese directly. "Until you showed up."

There it was. The thing they'd been circling.

Reese felt the weight of it settle in her chest. She'd come here to find Lauren Foss. She'd succeeded. And now Dana was asking her—without asking outright—what she was going to do about it.

“I don’t want to hurt you,” Reese said.

“Then don’t.”

“It’s not that simple.”

“Isn’t it?” Dana’s voice sharpened slightly. “You have a choice. You can walk away. Pretend you never found me. Tell people the case is still cold. Move on to the next story.”

“And your parents?”

Dana flinched. Just slightly, but Reese saw it.

“My parents have grieved for twenty-two years,” Dana said quietly. “If they find out now—if they find out I’ve been here, three streets away, and never said anything—” She stopped. Pressed her lips together. “It won’t undo the grief. It’ll just add anger to it.”

“You don’t know that.”

“I do.” Dana’s voice was firm. “I know what I took from them. I know what I did. And I know that telling them now won’t make it better. It’ll just make it different.”

Reese wanted to argue again. But she thought about Karen’s hands gripping those photos, about Bill saying *she’s not coming home*, about the room upstairs that hadn’t changed. Dana was probably right. Knowing Lauren was alive wouldn’t erase twenty-two years of grief. It would just reshape it into something harder to name.

“What do you want me to do?” Reese asked.

Dana looked at her for a long moment. “I want you not to air it. Not yet. Maybe not ever. I have a life here. It’s small, and it’s quiet, and it’s mine. I don’t want to lose it.”

“And if I do air it?”

“Then I lose it anyway.” Dana’s voice was calm, resigned. “My parents find out. The town finds out. His family finds out. And I’ll have to leave again. Start over somewhere else. Become someone new.” She paused. “I’m tired of being someone new.”

Reese felt something twist in her chest. She’d come here to tell a story. To do the work she was good at, the work that mattered. She’d told herself this was about finding answers, about giving the Fosses closure, about doing journalism that meant something.

But sitting here, across from a woman who’d spent twenty-two years rebuilding herself, Reese realized what she’d actually been doing.

She’d been treating Dana like content.

“I need time to think,” Reese said finally.

Dana nodded. “So do I.”

They sat there for a while, neither of them speaking. The river kept moving. The light kept fading. A few mosquitoes started to hum in the damp air near the trees.

Finally, Dana stood. “You know where to find me.”

“I do.”

Dana walked to her car, got in, and drove away without looking back. Reese stayed on the bench, alone, watching the river until the light was almost gone.

* * *

She didn’t go straight back to the motel.

Instead, she drove to the edge of town and parked in an empty lot near the old grain elevator. She sat there with the engine off, windows down, listening to the cicadas and trying to sort through what she was feeling.

Guilt. That was the easy one. She’d come here thinking she was doing something good—giving a family answers, solving a mystery, telling a story that mattered. But Dana was right. Reese had a choice. She could air it or she could walk away. And neither option felt clean.

If she aired it, she’d be exposing someone who’d spent two decades hiding from an abuser. She’d be ripping open a life that Dana had built with intention and care. She’d be turning survival into spectacle.

If she didn’t air it, she’d be complicit in the lie. She’d be letting Karen and Bill Foss keep grieving someone who was three streets away. She’d be protecting Dana at their expense.

Both choices hurt someone. That was the part Reese couldn’t get around.

She thought about Marisol, about the way she’d pitched this episode in the first place. *Lauren Foss, disappeared 2004, small-town mystery, never solved.* Marisol had approved it in five minutes. If Reese called her now and said *she’s alive, I found her*, Marisol would tell her exactly what to do. Step by step. Interview strategy, release schedule, network outreach. They’d have it planned in an hour.

But Reese didn’t call.

She just sat there in the dark, listening to the cicadas, and felt the weight of what she knew pressing down on her chest like something physical.

The story wasn’t about what happened to Lauren Foss anymore.

It was about what Reese was going to do now that she had the answer.

* * *

Back at the motel, Reese sat on the bed with her phone in her hand. Marisol's name was at the top of her recent calls. It would be so easy. Two taps. Three rings. And then someone else would be making the decisions.

But that wasn't how this worked.

Reese had spent five years telling other people's stories. She'd sat across from grieving mothers and convicted killers and witnesses who didn't want to talk. She'd recorded it all, edited it down, turned it into episodes that people listened to while they drove to work or folded laundry or cooked dinner. She'd told herself it was journalism. That it mattered. That she was documenting something real.

But she'd never had to decide whether telling the story would destroy the person at the center of it.

Until now.

Reese put the phone down and stared at the ceiling. The fluorescent light buzzed. The mini-fridge hummed. Outside, a car door slammed, and someone laughed, and the sound faded into the distance.

She thought about Dana's voice: *I'm tired of being someone new*.

She thought about Karen's voice: *I just want to know she didn't suffer*.

She thought about her own voice, recorded on a hundred episodes, always asking the same questions. *What happened? Why did it happen? Who's responsible?*

But maybe those weren't the right questions anymore.

Maybe the question now was: *Who gets to decide when a story is told?*

Reese rolled onto her side and pulled the scratchy motel blanket over her shoulders. Sleep didn't come. She lay there in the dark, eyes open, and felt the shape of the choice settling into her like something she couldn't shake.

She'd come to Millbrook Falls to find a missing woman.

She'd found her.

And now she didn't know what came next.

Chapter 4: The Missing Pieces

Reese went back to the sheriff's office the next morning. This time, she didn't call ahead.

The same young deputy was at the front desk, pecking at the same ancient computer. He looked up when the door opened, then picked up the phone without waiting for her to ask. A minute later, Tozer emerged from the back hallway. He didn't look surprised to see her.

"Ms. Calloway."

"Sheriff. Do you have a minute?"

His jaw tightened slightly, but he nodded. "Come on back."

Reese followed him to the same small office. The fluorescent lights buzzed overhead. The missing person flyer was still on the bulletin board, Lauren's graduation photo watching them from across the room.

Tozer sat behind his desk. He didn't offer Reese a chair this time, so she stayed standing.

"I've been going through the case file," Reese said. "The one you gave me."

"And?"

"And it's incomplete. There's an initial report, a few interviews, and then nothing. No follow-up after the first month. No search logs. Nothing."

"I told you—there wasn't much to search."

"That's what you said." Reese kept her voice even. "But I'm wondering why the investigation stopped so quickly. Lauren Foss was nineteen. She had a car, a purse, an apartment full of her things. She just vanished. And after four weeks, the case went cold."

Tozer leaned back in his chair. His face gave nothing away. "Sometimes that's how it goes."

"Is it?"

"You think we didn't do our jobs?"

"I think someone decided not to." Reese paused. "I'm trying to understand why."

Tozer was quiet for a long moment. The fluorescent lights hummed. Outside, a truck rumbled past on Main Street.

"Some people leave because they need to," Tozer said finally. His voice was careful, deliberate. "You don't drag them back if they don't want to be found."

Reese went very still. The words hung in the air between them, heavy and deliberate.

"Did you know?" she asked quietly.

Tozer looked at her. His face didn't change, but something shifted in his eyes. Guilt. Defensiveness. Something else she couldn't name.

He didn't answer.

Reese waited. Five seconds. Ten. The silence stretched.

Tozer finally spoke. "If you're asking me if I knew Lauren Foss was in danger, the answer is I suspected. If you're asking me if I knew where she went, the answer is no. But I knew she had reasons for leaving. Good reasons. And I didn't see the point in dragging her back to a situation that would've put her in more danger."

"Her parents didn't know that."

"No." Tozer's voice was flat. "They didn't."

Reese felt something cold settle in her chest. "You let them grieve for twenty-two years."

"I let their daughter stay safe."

"Those aren't the same thing."

"No," Tozer said. "They're not."

They stared at each other across the desk. Reese wanted to shout, to demand answers, to ask how he could make that choice and live with it for two decades. But she didn't. Because she could see it in his face—he'd been living with it. Every day. Every year. The weight of it had worn grooves into him.

"Is there anything else?" Tozer asked.

Reese shook her head. She didn't trust herself to speak.

She turned and left without another word. The fluorescent lights buzzed behind her as she walked down the hall and out into the bright morning sun.

* * *

Back in the motel room, Reese opened her laptop and started digging.

She'd already searched for Lauren Foss a dozen times, but now she was looking for something different. She wasn't looking for Lauren. She was looking for the gaps. The things that should have been in the investigation but weren't.

She started with the local newspaper archives. The Millbrook Falls Gazette had covered the disappearance in 2004—front page for two weeks, then sporadic updates, then nothing. Reese scrolled through the articles, taking notes.

March 18, 2004: Local Woman Reported Missing

March 25, 2004: Search Efforts Continue for Lauren Foss
April 2, 2004: Sheriff's Office Asks Public for Information
April 15, 2004: Family Holds Vigil for Missing Daughter

And then the coverage just… stopped. No follow-up articles. No updates. It was as if the story had been quietly shelved.

Reese found one more mention, dated May 10, 2004. A brief paragraph buried on page six: *Investigation into the disappearance of Lauren Foss continues, though Sheriff Roy Macklin says there are no new leads at this time.*

That was it. After that, nothing.

Reese opened a new tab and searched for the fiancé's name. She'd heard it from Dana, from Janet Kowalski, but she hadn't looked him up yet. Now she typed: *Holcomb Millbrook Falls 2004.*

The results loaded. The first hit was an obituary from 2018 for Thomas Holcomb Sr., local businessman and philanthropist. Survived by his wife, his two sons, and four grandchildren. The second hit was a news article about a donation the Holcomb family had made to the county hospital in 2015. The third was a mention in a high school sports article from 2002.

Reese kept scrolling. She found a wedding announcement from 2006: *Marcus Holcomb weds Emily Patterson.* There was a photo—Marcus in a tux, smiling, his new bride beside him. He looked clean-cut, handsome, entirely ordinary.

This was the man Dana had fled from.

Reese clicked back to the 2004 articles and searched more carefully. She found it buried in the April 2 coverage: *Sheriff's office interviewed Lauren's fiancé, Marcus Holcomb, who stated he had not seen her since the previous weekend. Holcomb, 23, said he believed Lauren may have needed time alone and would return when she was ready.*

No follow-up. No second interview. The article moved on to other potential leads—none of which went anywhere.

Reese sat back and stared at the screen. The blue light made her eyes ache.

The pattern was there, clear and deliberate. The investigation had started, questions had been asked, and then it had quietly stopped. No one had pushed. No one had demanded answers. The Holcomb name had appeared once, been cleared once, and never come up again.

This wasn't incompetence. It was a choice.

A coordinated choice.

Reese felt sick.

* * *

Her phone rang. She glanced at the screen: Marisol.

Reese almost didn't answer. But she knew if she didn't, Marisol would just keep calling.

She picked up. "Hey."

"Hey yourself." Marisol's voice was bright, businesslike. "So I've been hearing things."

Reese's stomach dropped. "What kind of things?"

"The good kind. Someone in your network mentioned you're onto something big with the Foss case. Is that true?"

Reese closed her eyes. "Who told you that?"

"Doesn't matter. Is it true?"

"It's complicated."

"Complicated is good, Reese. Complicated means it's a story." Marisol's enthusiasm was palpable, even over the phone. "I've already started pitching it to networks. Major break in a twenty-two-year-old cold case? They're interested. Really interested. But I need something from you. A draft. An outline. Something I can show them."

"I'm not ready."

"You've been there almost a week. What have you been doing?"

"Talking to people. Gathering tape."

"Great. So you have tape. Send me something. I need it by end of week."

"Marisol—"

"Friday, Reese. I know you've got this. Just send me what you have, and we'll work with it." She paused. "This is big, right? This is the kind of story that gets attention."

Reese thought about Dana's face by the river. *I'm tired of being someone new*.

"Yeah," she said quietly. "It's big."

"Good. I knew you'd pull through. Send me the draft by Friday." Marisol hung up before Reese could respond.

Reese set the phone down and stared at it. Her chest felt tight, like something was pressing down on her ribs.

Friday. Three days.

She could do it. She had the story. She had the facts. She knew where Lauren Foss was, why she'd left, how she'd survived. She could write it up, send it to Marisol, and let the machinery of production take over. It would be out of her hands.

Except it wouldn't. Because once the episode aired, Dana's life would be over. The quiet, small existence she'd built would collapse. The Holcombs would know. The town would know. Karen and Bill would know.

And Reese would be the one who made that happen.

She pushed the laptop away and put her head in her hands.

* * *

That afternoon, Reese drove around town and knocked on doors.

She started with Margaret Flynn, a retired postal worker who'd been mentioned in one of the 2004 articles. Margaret lived in a small house on the edge of town, the yard neat and carefully tended. She answered the door with a cautious smile.

"Can I help you?"

"Ms. Flynn? My name is Reese Calloway. I'm working on a story about Lauren Foss. I was hoping I could ask you a few questions."

The smile faded. "I already talked to the police back then. I don't have anything new to say."

"I understand. I'm just trying to get a fuller picture of what happened. You knew the Foss family, didn't you?"

"Everyone knew everyone back then." Margaret's hand tightened on the door frame. "I'm sorry, but I don't think I can help you."

"Did you know Lauren's fiancé? Marcus Holcomb?"

Margaret's face went carefully blank. "I knew of him. His family's well-known around here."

"Did you think he had anything to do with Lauren's disappearance?"

"I think you should talk to the sheriff's office if you have questions like that." Margaret started to close the door. "I'm sorry. I can't help you."

The door shut firmly.

Reese stood on the porch for a moment, then walked back to her car.

The next stop was Dorothy Chen, who'd been the church secretary in 2004. Dorothy was more polite, but just as evasive. Yes, she remembered Lauren. Yes, it was tragic. No, she didn't remember anything unusual before Lauren disappeared. And no, she didn't feel comfortable speculating about the Holcombs.

The third interview was with Harold Preston, who'd run the general store back then. He was in his eighties now, sitting on his front porch with a glass of iced tea. He let Reese sit down, which

felt like progress.

“Lauren was a sweet girl,” he said. “Shame what happened.”

“What do you think happened?”

Harold shrugged. “Hard to say. Could be a lot of things.”

“Do you think the investigation was thorough?”

Harold took a long sip of his tea. “I think Roy Macklin did what he thought was right at the time.”

“And what was that?”

“That’s not for me to say.”

Reese tried a few more questions, but Harold deflected them all with the same gentle evasiveness. Finally, Reese thanked him and stood to leave.

As she reached the porch steps, Harold spoke again.

“You talk to Vera Kowalski yet?”

Reese turned. “I talked to Janet Kowalski. Is Vera related?”

“Janet’s mother-in-law. Lives over on Birch Street. House with the blue shutters.” Harold looked at her over the rim of his glass. “She’s been around a long time. Sees a lot.”

“Thank you.”

Reese drove to Birch Street. The house with the blue shutters was small and tidy, flower boxes in the windows. An elderly woman answered the door almost immediately, as if she’d been expecting someone.

“Vera Kowalski?”

“That’s me.” Vera was tiny, sharp-eyed, her white hair pinned back neatly. “You’re the one asking about Lauren Foss.”

Reese blinked. “How did you—”

“Small town.” Vera stepped back and gestured inside. “You might as well come in.”

The living room was cluttered but clean, full of knickknacks and old photos. Vera gestured to a chair and sat across from Reese, her hands folding a dish towel in her lap.

“You want to know about Lauren,” Vera said. It wasn’t a question.

“Yes.”

“You want to know why no one found her.”

Reese hesitated. “I want to understand what happened.”

Vera's hands kept folding the towel, precise and rhythmic. She didn't look at Reese. "If someone's safe, why would you go looking for them?"

The words landed like a stone dropped into still water.

Reese's breath caught. "You knew."

"I didn't know anything for certain." Vera's voice was quiet, matter-of-fact. "But I saw things. Heard things. Lauren came into the post office once with a bruise on her arm. Said she'd tripped. I didn't believe her. Neither did Margaret Flynn, but we didn't say anything. It wasn't our place."

"Did you know she was planning to leave?"

"No. But when she disappeared, I wasn't surprised." Vera finally looked up, meeting Reese's eyes. "And I wasn't sorry."

Reese felt something cold settle in her stomach. "The town knew. Not everyone, but enough people knew."

"Some people knew she was in danger. Some people guessed she'd left. Some people put two and two together and decided it was better not to say anything." Vera set the towel down carefully. "The Holcombs are a powerful family. Always have been. If Lauren came back, or if anyone made a fuss about where she'd gone, it wouldn't have ended well for her."

"So you all just… protected the lie."

"We protected a girl who needed protecting." Vera's voice was firm. "That's not the same thing."

Reese wanted to argue. But she thought about Dana by the river, about the way she'd said *I had a reason for leaving*, and she couldn't.

"Her parents didn't know," Reese said quietly.

Vera's face softened slightly. "No. They didn't. And that's the hardest part. Karen and Bill, they're good people. They've been grieving all these years, and that's not right. But telling them wouldn't have brought Lauren back. It would've just put her in danger again."

"So you chose Lauren over them."

"I chose to let a scared nineteen-year-old girl stay safe." Vera looked at Reese directly. "If you've found her, if you know where she is—what are you going to do about it?"

Reese didn't have an answer.

Vera nodded, as if she'd expected that. "You came here to tell a story. But some stories aren't yours to tell. You might want to think about that before you go any further."

Reese left without saying anything else.

* * *

That night, she drove to Maple Street and parked across from the Foss house.

The lights were on inside. Through the front window, she could see Karen moving past—just a silhouette, but Reese recognized the shape of her. Karen disappeared into another room. A moment later, a lamp clicked off upstairs. Bill, probably, heading to bed.

Reese sat in the car with the engine off, watching the house. The warm glow of the windows. The quiet street. The normalcy of it all.

She could walk up to that door right now. Knock. Wait for Karen to answer. Say the words that would change everything: *Your daughter is alive. She's been here for eight years. She works at the hardware store on Main Street.*

Reese imagined Karen's face. The way the news would break her open. Or piece her back together. Or both at once, impossible to separate.

She thought about what Dana had said: *It won't undo the grief. It'll just make it different.*

She thought about what Vera had said: *Some stories aren't yours to tell.*

She thought about her own voice in a hundred episodes, asking the same questions. *What happened? Why? Who's responsible?*

But those weren't the questions anymore. The question now was simpler and harder: *What do you do when telling the truth will hurt everyone involved?*

Reese sat there for twenty minutes, her hands on the steering wheel, her chest tight with something that felt like grief and guilt and anger all mixed together.

Finally, she started the engine and drove away.

She didn't knock on the door.

She couldn't. Not yet. Because once she told Karen and Bill, there would be no taking it back. The machinery would start moving. Choices would be made. Lives would change.

And Reese still didn't know if that was the right thing to do.

Back at the motel, she lay on the bed in the dark and stared at the ceiling. Outside, the cicadas hummed. The neon sign from the gas station next door cast red shadows through the curtains.

She thought about Tozer's face when he'd said *I let their daughter stay safe.*

She thought about the town's silence—not ignorance, not cruelty, but a collective choice to protect someone who needed protecting.

She thought about Marisol's voice: *This is big. This is the kind of story that gets attention.*

And she thought about Dana, working behind a hardware store counter, ringing up paint and hinges and batteries, living a small, quiet life under a name that wasn't hers.

Reese had come here to find answers. She'd found them. And now she was drowning in them, and she didn't know how to get to shore.

Friday was three days away. The deadline was real. She had to decide.

But lying there in the dark, the only thing she knew for certain was that whatever choice she made, someone would be hurt.

And she would be the one who hurt them.

Chapter 5: The Pressure

Marisol called at seven in the morning. Reese was already awake. She had been awake for most of the night, watching the red glow of the gas station sign crawl across the ceiling, waiting for a decision that wouldn't come.

She answered on the second ring.

"I need the draft," Marisol said. No hello. "Today. This morning. I have a call with a network at eleven, and I told them you were sitting on something they'd want."

Reese sat up. The motel sheets scratched against her legs. "I don't have a draft."

"Then write one. You've been there a week. You have interviews. You have the family. You have whatever it is you won't tell me." Marisol's voice had lost the brightness from the earlier call. This was the version of her that closed deals. "I cannot keep stalling people with 'it's complicated.'"

"It is complicated. There are people involved. If I send you something now, I can't take it back."

"That's what makes it a good story, Reese. Send me something."

"Marisol, listen. I'm not being precious. I'm saying if this goes out the way you're thinking, it doesn't just air. It lands on people who are still living here."

A pause. Then, quieter, more tired than angry: "That's every episode we make. You know that. You've always known that."

Reese did know that. She had built a career on it.

"I need until—"

"You had until Friday. It's Thursday. I'm pulling the episode if I don't have pages by noon." Marisol exhaled into the phone, a sharp little sound. "I am trying to protect your work. I cannot protect a blank document."

The line went dead.

Reese sat with the phone against her ear for a few seconds after, listening to nothing. Then she set it on the nightstand. The laptop on the desk was still open from the night before, the screen gone dark. In the black glass she could see her own face, pale and unfocused, a person who had run out of delays.

She had nothing to send. Not a draft. Not an outline. Not even a lie that would hold until Monday.

Noon. Five hours.

She picked up the phone again, then put it down. Then she got dressed and drove to the hardware store.

* * *

Dana was restocking a bin of screws when Reese came in. A man in a ball cap was at the counter, arguing about a return. Reese waited by the paint chips until he left. The store smelled the same as it had the first time—sawdust, oil, the faint chemical bite of something in aisle two.

Dana looked at her. Waited.

"Can we meet?" Reese said. "Same place. After you close. I wouldn't ask if it could wait."

Dana tore a strip off a receipt roll, wrote a number on it in small, careful digits, and slid it across the counter. She didn't look around. She didn't lower her voice. She just went back to the screws.

Reese took the paper and left.

She spent the rest of the morning in the motel parking lot with the engine off, typing sentences she deleted. *In 2004, a nineteen-year-old woman vanished from Millbrook Falls.* That was the opening she'd used in her head since Minneapolis. It still worked as a sentence. It did not work as the thing she was actually holding.

At eleven fifty, Marisol texted: *?*

Reese typed: *I need more time. I'll call you tonight.*

She sent it. Marisol did not reply.

* * *

The picnic area was emptier than last time. The river had dropped another inch. Reese got there first and sat on the same bench, the wood cold through her jeans. She had not brought the recorder. She had thought about it in the car and left it in the trunk, as if that were a moral position and not just a habit she was afraid to break.

Dana's sedan pulled in at six twenty. She walked over without hurrying. She sat this time. She kept her hands in her lap.

"They're putting a clock on it," Reese said. "My producer. She's already talking to networks. She thinks I have a break in the case. She wants pages. If I don't send them, she pulls the episode."

Dana listened. She did not interrupt. She did not look away.

"I haven't told her who you are," Reese said. "I haven't told her I found you. But she knows I'm sitting on something, and she's not going to stop asking. And people in town have noticed I'm asking about the Holcombs. That's going to travel."

Dana nodded once, as if she had already done this math.

"I thought I'd have more time," she said.

It was the smallest she had sounded since the river. Not pleading. Just tired, the way a person sounded when they had been bracing for a knock that finally came.

“I don’t want to hurt you,” Reese said.

“I know.”

They sat. A mosquito landed on the table and stayed there. The air had gone cooler with the sun.

Dana did not ask her to kill the episode. She did not ask her to lie to Marisol. She did not ask for a plan. She stood, brushed gravel from her jeans, and said, “Do what you have to do.”

Then she walked back to her car. Her shoulders were lower than they had been when she arrived. The gravel under her boots was loud in the quiet.

Reese stayed on the bench until the sedan’s taillights disappeared down County Road 14. She had come here hoping Dana would tell her not to. Hoping the decision would be taken out of her hands.

Dana had given her permission instead.

That was worse.

* * *

The knock came just after eight.

Reese was sitting on the motel bed with her laptop open to a blank document when she heard it—three short raps, not the housekeeping knock, not the manager. She closed the laptop and went to the door. Through the peephole: a man in a collared shirt, early thirties, standing far enough back that she could see he had both hands visible.

She opened the door but didn’t step aside.

“Ms. Calloway,” he said. His voice was soft, almost pleasant. He smelled like cologne that had cost more than the room. “I hope I’m not interrupting.”

“Who are you?”

“A neighbor, more or less. I heard you were in town working on a project. The Foss girl. That’s a sad story. People around here have lived with it a long time.” He smiled without showing much of it. “I just wanted to make sure you were finding what you needed. And that you understood—some families in this county have been through enough. They don’t always appreciate being pulled into other people’s work.”

“I didn’t catch your name.”

“No, you didn’t.” He glanced past her into the room, then back to her face. “You’ve been asking questions about my family. That’s your right. It’s a free country. I’m only suggesting you think

about whether those questions are going to help anyone. Lauren Foss has been gone a long time. Digging her up now—so to speak—doesn't bring her back. It just stirs things that settled."

He said it like advice. Like weather.

"Is that a request?" Reese asked.

"It's a conversation." He took a step back, still smiling. "Have a good night. Drive safe while you're here."

He walked to a dark SUV parked two spaces down, got in, and left without looking at the motel again.

Reese shut the door. Her hands were shaking. She sat on the edge of the bed and waited until they stopped, then texted Tozer: *Someone just came to my room. Wouldn't give a name. Early thirties. Asking me to drop the Foss story. Holcomb?*

The phone rang thirty seconds later.

"That was a Holcomb, wasn't it," Reese said.

Tozer's breath came through the speaker, slow. "Probably. Younger one, if he wouldn't give you a name. They know you're circling something."

"Are you going to stop them?"

A long pause. A chair creaked.

"I don't know," Tozer said.

He hung up.

Reese set the phone down and looked at the door. The cologne was still in the room. She opened the window. Cicadas. A truck on the county road. Nothing that sounded like help.

She had told herself this was not a thriller. No one was going to drag her into a car. The man had been polite. He had used the word *conversation*. That was how people like him did it. They did not have to raise their voices. They only had to remind you that they were in the room.

Dana had been living with that reminder for twenty-two years.

* * *

Reese paced.

The room was too small for it. Six steps to the bathroom, six steps back. She picked up the recorder because her hands needed an object. She did not think about the red light until it was already on.

"Testing," she said, and then she was not testing.

“What’s the point of the work I do if it just makes things worse? I keep saying I want to do something that matters, and what I mean is I want to be the person who found the thing. I want the episode. I want Marisol off my back. I want Karen Foss to stop holding that photograph like it’s the last solid object in the house. And I cannot have all of that at once. I keep waiting for a version where nobody gets hurt, and there isn’t one. If I send the draft, Dana loses the life she built. If I don’t, I am doing what Tozer did. I am deciding for people. I am sitting on something that isn’t mine.”

She was talking too fast. She heard it and could not slow down.

“I left this town because I didn’t say anything. That’s the part I don’t put in the episodes. There was a girl in my class. Junior year. Everyone knew her boyfriend was—everyone knew. I saw her in the bathroom with her sleeve pulled down and I asked if she was okay and she said she was fine and I said okay. I said okay. And then I graduated and I got out and I told myself I would do better from a distance. Record it. Frame it. Make it useful. And now I’m standing in the same kind of silence and I still don’t know how to speak without making it worse.”

Her voice cracked on *worse*. She kept going anyway, looping the same three problems, naming Marisol, naming Dana, naming the Fosses, naming the man at the door. After a while there were no new sentences, only the same ones in a different order.

She stopped the recording. The red light went out.

She looked at the file on the little screen. Ten minutes and change. Her own voice, stored like everyone else’s.

She deleted it.

The room went quiet in a way that felt worse than the talking. She sat on the floor with her back against the bed and waited for something in her to settle. Nothing did. She could not make Karen whole without breaking Dana. She could not protect Dana without leaving Karen in the year 2004. She could not satisfy Marisol without turning a living woman into a cold-case headline.

Someone was going to be hurt. She had known that since the river. Knowing it and living inside it were different jobs, and she was failing both.

* * *

She did not remember deciding to open the laptop. She was just there, at the desk, headphones on, the Foss interview loaded because it was the first file in the folder and her hands had gone to what they knew.

Karen’s voice filled the cheap earbuds, closer than the room.

I just want to know she didn’t suffer. That’s all. I don’t care if we ever know what happened, really. I just want to know she’s not—

Reese paused it.

Rewound.

Listened again.

The sentence was not a request for an episode. It was not a request for a suspect, or a body, or a theory that would play well in a third act. Karen had said she wanted to know her daughter had not suffered. Underneath that, the thing Bill had named out loud: she wanted to know if Lauren was dead.

Reese sat with that until the recording's room tone became a hiss in her ears.

The Fosses did not need a podcast. They needed to know their daughter was alive. Not as a reveal. Not as content. Not as the thing Marisol could take to a network at eleven o'clock. They needed it the way you needed a fact that had been withheld from you for twenty-two years: privately, and soon, and from someone who would not make them perform their shock for a microphone.

Reese pulled the headphones off.

She still did not know what the episode should be. She still did not know what to tell Marisol at noon, or tonight, or ever. Those were later problems. This one had a shape.

She picked up her phone and opened a new message to the number on the receipt.

I want to help. Let me try.

She sent it.

The room stayed still. The fridge hummed. She did not pace. She sat on the bed and watched the screen stay empty, minute after minute, until watching it became the only thing she was doing.

An hour. Then another.

She thought about sending more—an explanation, a plan, an apology. She did not. Dana had spent two decades measuring words. She would answer when she had one, or she would not answer at all.

Reese left the phone face-up on the pillow and turned off the lamp. Sleep still did not come, but the waiting was different now. It had a direction.

The screen lit up sometime after midnight. One word, then the period after it, as if Dana had typed it, deleted it, and typed it again.

Okay.

Reese read it twice. She set the phone down carefully, the way you set down a glass that was fuller than it looked.

Tomorrow she would go to Dana first, and then—if Dana still wanted it—to Maple Street. No

recorder. No draft. No network call.

It was the first thing she had decided all week without building an exit into it.

Outside, the cicadas had gone quiet. The gas station sign still threw its red across the curtains. Reese lay on her side and looked at the dark and did not feel better, exactly. She felt finished with the part where she pretended that waiting was the same as being careful.

Chapter 6: The Reckoning

Reese bought two coffees at the gas station before the sky had fully committed to morning. The cups burned her fingers through the cardboard sleeves. She drove to the hardware store lot with the heat on and the radio off and waited with the engine running because the dashboard clock said ten to six and Dana had said she would come before the owner unlocked the doors.

Dana's sedan pulled in at 5:52. She got out in the same jeans she wore behind the counter. She stood for a second with her hand on the roof, looking at Reese's rental as if it might still be a mistake, then walked over and opened the passenger door.

The windshield had fogged at the edges. Reese handed her a cup. Dana took it with both hands and held it in her lap without drinking.

"We don't have to do this today," Reese said.

"If we don't do it today, I won't do it." Dana's voice was steady. Her knuckles were white on the cup. "I spent eight years walking past Maple Street on purpose. I can do it once with someone in the car."

"No recorder. No phone on the table. Nothing goes into an episode unless you say so. If you change your mind in the driveway, we leave."

Dana nodded. She looked at the hardware store's dark windows. "I called in. Said I had a family thing. That's the first time I've used those words in twenty years."

"I'll be there with you."

Dana's mouth moved like she was testing a word. "Thank you."

They sat with the heater ticking. A delivery truck passed on Main Street, too early for anyone to notice two women in a rental car. Reese watched Dana's breath ghost the plastic lid and did not fill the quiet. When Dana said, "All right," Reese put the car in gear.

* * *

She stopped at the county building first.

Dana stayed in the passenger seat with her coffee, staring at the courthouse lawn. Reese said she would be ten minutes. Dana said, "If he tries to talk you out of it, don't let him. I've already been talked out of it. I'm done with that."

Inside, the deputy at the desk looked at the clock and then at Reese. Tozer was already in. He always was.

His office smelled like old paper and coffee that had sat too long. He did not offer a chair. Reese did not take one.

“I’m going to the Foss house this morning,” she said. “With her. She’s going to tell them herself. I’m only there so she doesn’t have to walk up that porch alone.”

Tozer sat very still. The missing person flyer was still on the bulletin board. Lauren at graduation, smiling at a camera that had no idea what the next twenty-two years would cost.

“You found her,” he said.

“I found her weeks ago. You already knew that.”

He looked at his desk. The chair creaked when he shifted. Seconds went by. A phone rang somewhere down the hall and stopped.

“I thought I was protecting her,” he said. “I don’t know if I was.”

Reese waited. He did not add a speech. He did not ask where Dana had been living. He did not ask for a name he could write in a report.

“Will you try to stop me?”

He shook his head once. “No. I won’t stop you.”

He did not stand. He did not offer to come. He did not apologize to a room that did not include Karen Foss. Reese left him there with his hands flat on the blotter. The door closed on the fluorescent hum, and the hallway felt colder for how little he had given and how much it had cost him to give it.

In the car, Dana said, “Well?”

“He won’t get in the way.”

Dana looked toward Maple Street as if she could see it through brick. “That’s more than I expected.”

* * *

The Foss house looked the same as it had on the first day: mowed lawn, faded paint, porch that sagged under its own history. Reese parked on the street. She did not take her bag. She checked her pockets for the recorder out of habit and left it in the glove box.

Dana sat until the engine ticked itself quiet. Then she opened the door.

Reese knocked. The doorbell still didn’t work. She could hear it try.

Karen opened the door in a cardigan, hair already done, the face of a woman who had been awake for hours because sleep was not a reliable country. She smiled when she saw Reese—thin, automatic, the smile from the interview.

Then she looked past Reese.

Dana stood one step down, not quite on the porch, as if the threshold were a thing you had to be invited across. For a second Karen's eyes moved over her the way you look at a stranger bringing a petition. Polite confusion. Then the confusion stalled.

Karen's hand found the door frame. Her mouth opened and did not make a word. The color left her face in a way Reese had seen on tape, in other houses, and had never wanted to see without a microphone between her and it.

"Lauren?"

Dana nodded.

Karen made a sound that was not language. She swayed. Reese's arm came up and then dropped because Karen was already reaching, not for Reese, for Dana's face, both hands, shaking so hard her rings clicked. She held Dana's cheeks like she was checking that the bones were real.

"Bill," she said, and then louder, "Bill—"

He came from the back of the house in slippers, slower, frowning at the interruption. He looked at Reese first. Then at the woman on his porch. He did not speak. He stood in the hallway light with his mouth slightly open, and for a long time the only sound was Karen crying in short, ugly bursts she was trying to swallow and failing.

"It's me," Dana said. Her voice broke on *me*. "Mom. It's me."

Karen pulled her inside. Not gently. The kind of pull that had been waiting in the muscles for two decades. Bill did not move until Dana was in the living room, among the photographs, and then he walked in like a man entering a room he no longer trusted.

Reese shut the door behind them and stayed near it. Hands in her pockets. She looked at the graduation photo on the side table and then looked away.

"Where were you?" Karen said. She still had one hand on Dana's sleeve. "Where have you been? We looked. We looked and they said—Bill, she was at the hardware store. People said—I didn't believe them. I thought they were cruel."

"I know." Dana's eyes were wet. She had not cried at the river. She had not cried in the car. She was crying now, quietly, as if she had forgotten the instructions. "I was—I left. I had to leave. I couldn't tell you. I thought if I told you he'd find me."

Bill sat down hard in the recliner. "The Holcomb boy."

Dana flinched at the name. She did not deny it.

"You let us think you were dead," Bill said. His voice broke in the middle of *dead* and came back thinner. "Twenty-two years, Lauren. Your mother kept your room. I told her to stop. I told her you weren't coming. I was wrong, and I was also—" He stopped. His hands were shaking in his lap. "I don't know what I am."

“I’m sorry.” Dana said it to the carpet first, then to them. “I’m so sorry. I know it doesn’t—”

“Don’t you tell me it doesn’t,” Karen said, and then she was angry, the anger arriving late and all at once, as if it had been stored behind the grief and had finally found a door. “Don’t you stand in this house and tell me sorry like it’s a receipt. I sat in that chair and I talked to a podcaster about my dead daughter while you were ringing up paint. Do you understand that? Do you understand what that is?”

“Yes.”

“Are you safe?” Karen’s anger snagged on the other thing, the mother thing, and the two of them existed in the same breath. “Is he—does he know you’re here?”

“He doesn’t know I’m me. Some people do. Enough people. I’ve been careful.” Dana wiped her face with the heel of her hand. “I work at the store. I have an apartment. I didn’t come back to hurt you. I came back because it was the last place I thought he’d look, and then I stayed because leaving again felt like dying a second time, and I know how that sounds.”

Bill laughed once, no humor in it. “It sounds like our daughter.”

The photographs watched. Afternoon had not arrived yet; the light through the lace curtains was still the thin, honest light of morning, and it made everyone look older than the story they were trying to fit into one room.

Karen sat on the couch as if her knees had voted. She pulled Dana down beside her and did not let go of her wrist. The birthmark was visible. Karen stared at it. Her thumb passed over it once, checking.

“Why didn’t you write?” she whispered. “A letter. Anything. We wouldn’t have told. I would have— I don’t know what I would have done. I would have wanted to do the wrong thing, probably. That’s why you didn’t. I can hear that. I can hear it and I still want to shake you.”

“I know.”

They talked in pieces after that. Interrupted questions. Silences that lasted long enough for a car to pass outside. Karen asked about Chicago, about the name, about whether Dana had been hungry, about the wedding that never happened. Bill asked, once, if she had children, and Dana said no, and he nodded as if he had been bracing for a different answer. Dana asked if they had been all right, which was a stupid question, and Karen answered it anyway: they had not been all right. They had been a house with a clock that stopped in 2004.

Reese did not speak. When Karen looked at her, once, with a question in it—*did you know*—Reese only nodded, and Karen’s face did something complicated, gratitude and betrayal sharing the same muscle.

No one asked her to leave. No one asked her to stay. She was furniture with a pulse. That was the right job.

After a while Bill stood and went to the kitchen. Water ran. He came back with three glasses and

set them down too hard. He did not offer Reese one, then did, then looked embarrassed about the sequence. Reese shook her head.

Dana said, “I can’t be Lauren in town. Not out loud. Not yet. Maybe not for a long time. If that’s a condition of sitting here, I understand if you need me to go.”

Karen’s face crumpled again. “You are not going. You just got here.”

“I got here eight years ago,” Dana said, and Bill made a sound, and Karen closed her eyes.

It was not a reunion that resolved. It was a reunion that started. Reese understood the difference the way she understood a tape that ran out before the sentence finished.

When she finally stepped onto the porch, the light had shifted. Karen’s hand was still on Dana’s face in the doorway, tentative now, shaking less. Bill stood behind them, not touching anyone, crying in the slow, astonished way of a man who had already spent his allotment and had found more anyway.

Reese walked to the car and waited.

* * *

Dana came out twenty minutes later. Her eyes were swollen. She got in and shut the door and sat with her hands on her knees.

The engine hummed. Neither of them spoke until a neighbor walked a dog past the bumper and did not look in.

“Thank you,” Dana said. “I think.”

“I don’t know what I’m going to do about the episode.”

“Let me think about it. I’ll let you know.” Dana turned her head. “If you air anything—don’t name them. The family. I can live with a lot of things. I can’t live with giving him a reason to remember I exist.”

“I won’t name them.”

Dana nodded. She opened the door, then paused. “I’m going to work. If I don’t, I’ll sit in that living room until I disappear again, and I just got finished disappearing.”

She got out and walked down the sidewalk toward Main Street, small and steady, not looking back. Reese watched until she turned the corner. Then she sat with the quiet hum of the car and the shape of the house in the side mirror and felt, for the first time since the bridge, that she had done the part of the job that was not a job.

Her phone buzzed in the cup holder. Marisol.

Reese answered.

“I have been covering for you since yesterday,” Marisol said. No greeting. “The network call happened. I told them you had a family emergency. Do you have any idea how that sounds? Send the draft. Now. I am done being patient with this artistic-crisis routine.”

“I’m not running the episode the way we planned. I’ll explain later.”

Silence. Then, very precisely: “What does that mean?”

“It means I need a day. It means I am not going to put a name on the internet this afternoon because a calendar said Friday.”

Marisol hung up.

Reese looked at the phone until the screen went dark. She did not call back. She drove to the motel, lay on the made bed in her clothes, and slept without meaning to, a hard, dreamless drop that felt like the body collecting a debt.

* * *

Tozer was at the door in the morning with his hat in his hand.

Reese opened it in yesterday’s shirt. He held out a sealed envelope. She took it. The paper was heavy, the kind the county used for things that had to last in a file.

She opened it while he stood on the concrete slab. His handwriting was neat, a little old-fashioned. *Effective immediately. Earl Tozer.* A paragraph about serving the county, another about personal reasons, nothing that would satisfy a reporter and nothing that would protect him from one.

“You didn’t have to do this,” she said.

“Yeah, I did.”

He put his hat on. His boots hit the gravel of the lot, even, unhurried. He did not look at the gas station sign or the row of identical doors. He walked to his truck like a man who had finished a shift that had lasted twenty-two years.

Reese sat on the bed with the letter in both hands. The room was the same room. The fridge hummed. She exhaled, long enough that her shoulders dropped, and understood that making a thing right was not the same as undoing it. People were trying anyway. That had to count for something, even if the count would never come out even.

Chapter 7: Nobody Left

Three weeks later the Minneapolis apartment sounded like itself again: a bus at the corner, a neighbor's television through the wall, the refrigerator that clicked off and on as if it were thinking. Reese sat at the desk by the window with her headphones on and the timeline open. The city was a gray smear beyond the glass. She did not miss the motel. She missed, occasionally, the particular quiet of a town that went dark after nine.

The episode on the screen was not the one she had pitched in the car on the way into Millbrook Falls. It was not the one Marisol had described to a network. There was no cold-open with a missing girl and a ticking clock. There was a river, a hardware store mentioned only as a kind of place, a sheriff's office with a file that ended too soon. There were voices from 2026 talking around a hole in 2004.

Lauren's track sat on its own lane, colored differently from the rest. Reese had recorded it over two evenings on a secure line, Dana in her apartment after the store closed, door locked, a towel under it because she said she felt foolish and then did it anyway. Reese had run the audio through a pitch filter until the person speaking could have been anyone with a careful Midwestern cadence. No name. No workplace. No street. When Dana listened to the first pass she had said, "That's not me," and then, after a pause, "Good."

On the waveform, a sentence bloomed and flattened as Reese trimmed the breath before it.

The disguised voice said, *People think silence is the same as not knowing. Sometimes it's the opposite. Sometimes a whole town agrees, without a meeting, that a person is safer if she stays gone.*

Reese let it play. She did not add music under it. She had tried, two nights ago, and taken the music out because it made the sentence sound like a conclusion, and it was not one.

She had interviewed Vera Kowalski again, this time on the record, with Vera's conditions written in Reese's notebook: no Holcomb, no address, no claim that Vera had been a hero. Vera had said, on tape, that protecting someone and owning their story were neighbors that should not share a fence. Reese had kept that line. She had cut the one where Vera asked if Reese was going to be famous for this. The answer would have been no, and it would have sounded like a boast.

Tozer had not sat for an interview. Reese had not asked twice. She had a copy of the resignation letter in a folder she was not going to scan. In the episode he appeared only as a function: a department that closed a case, a man who later left the job. Listeners could do the rest of the arithmetic if they wanted. Most would not. That was the point.

She scrubbed forward to the Fosses. She had called Karen a week after the porch and asked, carefully, whether they wanted to be in it at all. Karen had said they would talk about the years, not about the hardware store, not about a name they were still learning how to say in the kitchen. Bill had gotten on the extension and said, "We are not a happy ending. Don't make us one." Reese had said she wouldn't. On the tape, Karen's voice still caught on *twenty-two*, but it

was a different catch than the first interview—less the sound of a door sealed shut, more the sound of a door that had been opened and would not close neatly.

Reese saved the session. The apartment was quiet in the way a finished mix was quiet: not empty, just decided. She sat back and listened to the last ninety seconds without touching the keys. It was good work. Smaller than her usual hour. Less certain. She could hear, in her own host track, the places where she had almost reached for a line that would make her sound wise, and had left the gap instead.

She exported the file before she could talk herself into one more pass.

* * *

Marisol called twenty minutes after the upload finished. Reese put her on speaker and set the phone on a stack of unopened mail.

“This isn’t what we talked about,” Marisol said. Her voice was crisper than it had been in the motel weeks, more distant, as if she had already moved the conversation into a column in a spreadsheet.

“I know.”

Paper shuffled on Marisol’s end. Reese pictured her at the kitchen table she used as an office, the same mug, the same frown she wore when a guest ran long.

“You didn’t name the woman. You didn’t name the family. You didn’t even land the disappearance. You made a forty-one-minute essay about a town being quiet on purpose.”

“That’s the episode.”

Marisol was silent long enough that Reese thought the call had dropped. Then: “It’s still good. Frustrating, but good. You’re lucky this works as a standalone. I already told the network the exclusive wasn’t happening. They were irritated. They will get over it. I will get over it. I am professionally annoyed, Reese. I want that on the record.”

“It’s on the record.”

“Don’t do this to me twice in a row.” A breath. Not quite a laugh. “Send me the show notes. I’ll write the listing so nobody thinks we lost the tape. We still have a show. We are still us. We are also not quite us. You understand that.”

“I know.”

“All right.” Marisol paused, and when she spoke again the edge had worn down to something almost like respect, which was worse, in a way, because it meant the cost was real. “I’ll schedule it for Tuesday. Standard slots. No extra ads. This one shouldn’t sit next to a vitamin discount.”

“Tuesday’s fine.”

The click when she hung up was small and clean. Reese left the phone where it was. The apartment did not change. She had drawn a line and Marisol had seen it and stepped over it without pretending it was not there. They would make other episodes. Some of them would be the old kind. This one would sit in the feed like a different accent, and anyone paying attention would hear it.

Reese could live with that.

* * *

The episode went up on a Tuesday. Reese did not watch the download numbers. She made eggs. She answered two listener emails that were about a different case, from a different month, and she did not tell those people she had just declined to solve a mystery in public.

On Friday morning an email arrived from Karen Foss. Subject line: *Thank you.*

Reese opened it at the desk, the window still gray, the cursor blinking in an empty reply field she was not ready to use.

Thank you for giving us our daughter back, even though it's not the way we thought. We're talking. It's hard. But we're talking. You did the right thing.

The punctuation was careful, the way Karen had been careful with the framed photographs, setting each one down as if it might break. There was no postscript about the episode's reviews. There was no request for a follow-up interview. There was a sentence about Sunday dinner, cancelled and then not cancelled, which Reese read as the only status update that mattered.

She read the email three times. The glow of the inbox made the words look slightly too bright. She did not reply. Not because she had nothing to say. Because *you're welcome* would have been the wrong size, and *I hope you're well* would have been a lie of shape if not of fact. She sat with it until the eggs went cold in the pan, then she got up and scraped them into the trash and made toast, which was the kind of ordinary repair she knew how to do.

Later she forwarded the message to no one. She put it in a folder labeled with Karen's name and left it there.

* * *

The postcard came on a Wednesday, mixed in with a utility bill and a grocery flyer. No return address. Postmark: Millbrook Falls. The front was a stock photo of the river in summer, bluer than the river had been, a heron that Reese did not remember seeing. The kind of card they sold at the gas station next to the beef jerky.

On the back, in the same small, careful digits Dana had used on the receipt:

Still here.

Two words. No name. Reese stood in the building's lobby with the mail in her hands and felt her mouth do something that was almost a smile and then wasn't, because smiling at a postcard in a lobby felt like claiming credit.

She carried it upstairs and propped it against the laptop, river-side out, until the glossy blue caught the afternoon and threw a cheap little sun on the wall. Then she turned it over again and left it that way, the handwriting facing her while she worked.

Dana was still Dana. The store still had a counter. Maple Street still had a porch. None of that had been converted into a twist. That was the whole message.

Reese touched the edge of the card once, the way you check that a thing is actually on the desk and not a thought, and went to make coffee.

* * *

She closed the laptop in the late afternoon, when the light in the apartment had gone the color of weak tea. The postcard stayed. The city went on being a city. Reese stood at the window with a mug and looked at a brick wall and a slice of sky and did not try to make them mean Millbrook Falls.

She thought about the bridge anyway. The metal grating. The low water. The way the town had looked exactly the same, which had felt like an accusation and was probably only a fact. She could go back. Not with a bag of mics. Not with a list. She could eat at the diner and not write anything down. She might. She might not. The not-knowing did not feel like a failure of nerve. It felt like a calendar with empty squares, which was a different kind of freedom than the one she had practiced at eighteen, when empty had meant *gone*.

She had left then because she had said okay in a bathroom and then packed a dorm room as if distance were the same as repair. She had left this time with a resignation letter in a folder and a postcard on a desk and a feed that would, on Tuesday, have asked a quieter question than her listeners were used to. The highway north did not care which version she was. She did. That would have to be enough.

Reese sat down and opened the notebook she used for ideas she was not ready to pitch. The paper was cheap. The pen skipped, then caught.

She wrote a first line about a man who ran a community garden on a lot the city kept threatening to sell. No disappearance. No file. Just a person trying to keep tomatoes alive between two bus routes. She did not know if it would hold for forty minutes. She did not know if Marisol would want it. She wrote the second sentence anyway, slower, hearing it in her head in the cadence she used when she was drafting out loud and then catching herself, and this time she did not catch herself. She let it be a sentence about dirt and a water bill and a neighbor who complained about bees.

The work looked different. Smaller on purpose. She was different too, not in a way that would

show up in a bio, only in the way her hand felt on the page: less like she was transcribing a world that would happen whether she arrived or not, more like she was choosing what to pick up and what to leave on the ground.

Outside, a bus sighed at the corner. Reese kept writing until the light thinned and the postcard's river went dull. She did not know if she would go back to Millbrook Falls. She knew she could, and that the knowing was not the same as running, and that leaving a place did not have to mean she had failed to stand in it.

She put the pen down. The notebook stayed open. The first line was still there, ordinary and unfinished, which was, for once, the point.

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